“Who won?” Khrushchev asked the delegation before answering the question himself and maintaining that he had achieved his principal goal. “I am of the opinion that we won. One must start from the final aims we set ourselves. What aim did the Americans have? To attack Cuba and get rid of the Cuban Republic, to establish a reactionary regime in Cuba. Things did not work out as they planned. Our main aim was to save Cuba, to save the Cuban revolution. That is why we sent missiles to Cuba. We achieved our objective—we wrenched the promise out of the Americans that they would not attack Cuba and that other countries on the American continent would also refrain from attacking Cuba.”

Khrushchev took the opportunity to blame Castro for aggravating the conflict and suggesting a nuclear strike against the United States. He also made a larger point about nuclear war, an issue on which he disagreed passionately with his main communist rival, Mao Zedong. He was eager to prove the Chinese communists wrong. “This clash (and we were truly on the verge of war) demonstrated that war today is not inevitably destined by fate, that it can be avoided. The Chinese claim was therefore once again refuted, as well as their assessments of the current era, the current balance of forces. Imperialism, as can be seen, is no paper tiger; it is a tiger that can give you a nice bite in the backside.”

Khrushchev presented himself not only as the savior of Cuba from imperialism but also of the whole world from nuclear war—a seasoned and reasonable politician who knew when and how to compromise, but also as a winner in the court of world public opinion, scoring points even with the capitalists. With his fellow communist Novotný, Khrushchev allowed himself to be open, if not cynical, in that regard. “One of the important consequences of the whole conflict and of our approach is the fact that the whole world now sees us as the ones who saved peace,” he argued. “I now appear to the world as a lamb. That is not bad either. The pacifist [Bertrand] Russell writes me thank-you letters. I, of course, have nothing in common with him, except that we both want peace.”[15]

To all appearances, Khrushchev’s explanations and bravado were accepted by his colleagues, de facto underlings, without question. The same applied to the Soviet media. *Pravda* and other leading newspapers published not only Russell’s letter to Khrushchev, praising him for his